

ZERO SUM: The Modern Thriller Roleplaying Game

Core Rulebook & Setting Guide (Expanded Global Horror Edition)

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CHAPTER 1: The Global Horror of Zero Sum

1.1 The Core Truth

Zero Sum is a tabletop roleplaying game set in the bleeding edge of 2026. This is a game of systemic horror. There are no monsters; instead, there are algorithmic bank runs, cartel hit-squads using commercial quadcopters with explosives, AI-generated blackmail, and extraordinary rendition flights to black sites. The players are outmatched, out-funded, and hunted across a global board.

1.3 The Grand Unification: The Paradigm Shift

The chaos of the 2020s is not random. The wars, the AI explosion, the crypto crashes, and the climate disasters are all interlocking gears of a single, coordinated meta-plot known as **The Paradigm Shift**. The ultimate goal of the highest-tier factions is the "Post-State Era": bankrupting national governments through proxy wars

and crises so that Algorithmic Corporate Hegemonies can take over. Every single crisis relies on the others to herd the global population into total compliance.

1.4 The Rules of the Universe

1. **The Panopticon is Real:** Digital footprints are permanent. Facial recognition, gait analysis, and cell-tower triangulation mean you are always being watched.
 2. **The Supply Chain is Blood:** The clean tech of the West is built on the horror of PMC-guarded cobalt mines in the DRC and cyber-cartels in Latin America. The horror is global.
 3. **Parallel Construction:** Intelligence agencies will illegally spy on you, then orchestrate a mundane traffic stop to legally arrest you.
 4. **The “Zero-Trust” Era:** Due to the AI explosion, video and audio evidence are meaningless to the public. You cannot just “leak” the truth; you must force the world to look at it.
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CHAPTER 2: The Psychological Burn Mechanics (Core Rules)

2.1 The D10 System & Difficulty Classes

Zero Sum uses a pool of 10-sided dice (D10) to resolve conflicts and operational challenges.

1. **Pool Assembly:** Determine the relevant **Attribute + Skill** total for the action. Gather that number of D10s.
2. **Success Threshold:** Roll the dice pool. Every die that lands on a **6, 7, 8, 9, or 10** counts as a **Success** (50% probability). A roll of a 10 counts as two Successes if the character possesses a relevant **Specialization** in that Skill.
3. **Difficulty Classes (DC):** The Game Master (GM) assigns a Difficulty Class based on the complexity, systemic friction, and level of threat:
 - * **DC 1 (Standard):** Routine professional actions performed under pressure. Requires 1 Success.
 - * **DC 2 (Challenging):** Complicated maneuvers executed under direct threat or active interference. Requires 2 Successes.
 - * **DC 3 (Hard):** Elite operations requiring absolute precision against competent opposition. Requires 3 Successes.
 - * **DC 4 (Extreme):** Nearly impossible actions attempting to bypass state-level security or overwhelming structural blockades. Requires 4 Successes.

2.2 Cognitive Load

The mind and body can only withstand so much tension before the cracks begin to show. A character's capacity to absorb immediate psychological shock, panic, and physical fatigue is tracked using their **Cognitive Load**. * **Load Capacity**: A character's maximum Cognitive Load is equal to their **Endurance** × 3. * **Gaining Load**: Players intentionally "spend" Cognitive Load to push their luck (e.g., "Take 1 Load to reroll a failed die") or automatically gain 1 Load at the end of a particularly harrowing scene. * **Fully Depleting Load**: If a character's Cognitive Load reaches its maximum capacity (filled to its limit), they immediately suffer a **Psychological Burn** (see Section 2.4).

2.3 Refined Desensitization Levels

When characters face truly horrific scenarios—such as discovering a family member's home has been bugged, witnessing an automated turret execution, or viewing a cartel torture video—the shock bypasses temporary load and leaves lasting damage. When a character fails a **Detachment** roll under these circumstances, they suffer a condition called **Desensitization**.

Desensitization manifests in three progressive levels of severity, applying **Situational Complications** (never permanent attribute penalties, to avoid a death spiral): * **Mild Desensitization**: Represents initial psychological scarring. It imposes a minor situational complication (e.g., *Hypervigilance*—you cannot reroll 1s on social checks; or *Numbness*—you take 1 extra minute to perform fine-motor tasks). * **Severe Desensitization**: Represents deep, debilitating psychological damage and inflicts a strict **behavioral restriction** (e.g., *Obsessive Paranoia*—the character cannot sleep in the same location twice; or *Panic Response*—the character must spend their first action in combat seeking cover). * **Psychological Burn (3rd Fail)**: If a character is forced to take a third Desensitization condition, or if they fail a Detachment roll while already possessing two active conditions, they immediately trigger a **Psychological Burn** (see Section 2.4). If a character fails a Detachment roll while their third slot is occupied, their psyche collapses entirely: they are retired permanently as a playable character.

2.4 Psychological Burn Mechanics

A **Psychological Burn** represents a catastrophic breaking point in a character's psychological defenses. It is triggered under two conditions: 1. **Load Overflow**: The character's Cognitive Load is fully depleted (filled to capacity). 2. **Desensitization Threshold**: The character accumulates **3 active Desensitizations**.

When a Burn occurs, the player must choose one of the following two devastating options to absorb the psychological collapse: *

Strain a Tie: The character heavily damages one of their active **Ties** (contacts, family members, or allies). In their panic or cold detachment, the character alienates them. The Tie requires intense narrative upkeep to fix, otherwise it cannot be used. *

Mental Scar: The character develops a clinical psychological disorder from the following list: * *Amnesia:* The character loses key memories, erasing a past contact or a professional skill (temporarily reducing a Skill to 0). * *Catatonia:* In high-cognitive load situations (such as the beginning of a firefight or a chase), the character must roll Detachment (DC 2) or freeze, becoming unable to take actions for the first round of the scene. *

Hallucinations: The character perceives false threats, ghost signals on their devices, or voices, forcing them to waste resources or make checks against threats that do not exist.

Once a Burn is resolved, the character's Cognitive Load is reset to 0, but the permanent scars remain.

2.5 Empathy & Ties Link

Human connection is a finite resource governed by one's psychological stability. * **Capacity:** A character's maximum number of active **Ties** is strictly limited to their current **Empathy** attribute. * **Emotional Withdrawal:** If a character suffers severe Desensitization related to Empathy, their Ties become strained. The character's emotional withdrawal, apathy, or paranoid isolation makes it difficult to maintain these relationships, requiring dedicated downtime to keep them active.

2.6 The Heat Level (1-10)

The GM tracks the group's global visibility. * **1-3 (Monitored):** Passive data scraping. * **4-6 (Targeted):** Bank accounts frozen, passports flagged, social credit wiped. * **7-9 (Hunted):** Cartel sicarios or Tier-1 operators dispatched. Blackmail released. * **10 (Erased):** Extraordinary rendition. A black bag over the head. Game over.

CHAPTER 3: Character Creation (Stats & Psychological Burn)

To survive in *Zero Sum*, a character's psychology is just as important as their physical capability.

3.1 The Attributes (Rated 1-5)

Characters are built on three dualities, containing six attributes.

The Mental Duality: * **Processing:** Raw logic, coding, data analysis, and mathematical deduction. * **Intuition:** Gut feeling, reading micro-expressions, sensing an ambush.

The Physical Duality: * **Kinetics:** Speed, stealth, sleight of hand, and driving under fire. * **Endurance:** Surviving sleep deprivation, resisting physical torture, and carrying heavy gear.

The Psychological Duality (The Horror Stats): * **Empathy:** How well you connect with others. High Empathy grants bonuses to social and persuasion skills but makes you highly vulnerable to Desensitization when you witness atrocities. * **Detachment:** Cold, calculated sociopathy. High Detachment protects you from Desensitization and Cognitive Load, but drastically lowers your ability to maintain Ties or trust others.

3.2 Core Skills (Rated 0-5)

- *Technical:* Cryptography, Signal Interception, Forensics, Sabotage.
- *Social:* Interrogation, Bureaucracy, Tradecraft, Subterfuge.
- *Physical:* Firearms (Penalized heavily), Evasion, Close-Quarters, Athletics.

3.3 The Desensitization System

Instead of simple “Health,” characters suffer specific Desensitization conditions when confronted by the horrors of the real world (e.g., watching a cartel flaying video, realizing your family is targeted, witnessing an automated execution). As detailed in Chapter 2, when a character fails a **Detachment** roll in a horrific situation, they gain a condition at either the **Mild** or **Severe** level: * **Paranoia (Severe):** You cannot sleep in the same place twice (behavioral restriction). * **Obsession (Severe):** You must pursue the conspiracy, regardless of the danger, checking every lead immediately (behavioral restriction). * **Apathy (Severe):** The horror has broken you. You withdraw emotionally from the world (you cannot utilize any remaining Ties during this state until treated).

CHAPTER 4: Equipment, Logistics & Economics

4.1 The Gear of the Hunted

- **Faraday Bags:** Essential. Without them, your electronics will betray you.
- **Stingray (IMSI Catcher):** A suitcase device to hijack cell towers.
- **Zero-Click Exploits:** Costs millions in crypto. Infects a phone instantly.
- **Psychological Burn Kits:** Military-grade chest seals and QuikClot. Hospitals will report you to the state.

4.2 Global Economics

- **Privacy Coins (Monero):** The only untraceable digital currency.
 - **The Hawala System & Gray Markets:** Moving physical gold, art, or cash across borders using ancient trust networks to avoid SWIFT banking oversight.
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CHAPTER 5: Combat & Autopsies (Why Violence Fails)

In *Zero Sum*, drawing a weapon is a failure state. * **Asymmetric Power:** You have a 9mm handgun. The PMC hunting you has thermal-optic sights, body armor, and legal immunity. * **The Forensic Nightmare:** Firing a gun leaves gunshot residue, casings, and acoustic signatures picked up by city-wide AcousticNet microphones. Police response is measured in seconds. * **Damage:** There are no HP sponges. A single bullet causes a **Severe Wound** (bleeding out, -2 to all physical rolls). Two bullets usually result in a **Critical Wound** (death within minutes).

CHAPTER 6: Factions & Global Crises

6.1 The Factions

- **The Five Eyes & Eastern Panopticons:** The global surveillance state. They control the cameras, the satellites, and the social credit scores.

- **The Cyber-Cartels:** Latin American syndicates that employ hackers alongside sicarios. They will live-stream the torture of your loved ones to force compliance.
- **The PMC Warlords:** Private armies guarding African resource mines. They represent the brutal, unregulated physical violence that powers the first world.
- **The Spyware Merchants:** Middle-Eastern and European corporate intelligence firms selling assassination software to autocrats.
- **The Sovereign Wealth Syndicates:** The trillion-dollar dark money networks hiding in offshore tax havens.

6.2 Wars & Existential Cover Operations

Wars in *Zero Sum* are massive laundering machines and R&D labs. * **Active Warzones (Eastern Europe, Middle East):** Used to test automated sniper turrets and facial recognition on captive populations. * **Climate Collapse:** Weaponized via “Disaster Capitalism.” PMCs secure fresh water aquifers during engineered crises. * **Bio-Security (Pandemics):** The threat of viruses is used to enforce mandatory DNA harvesting and digital movement-tracking passports.

CHAPTER 7: Real-World NPCs & Black Sites

7.1 Key Figures

- **The Architect:** Erratic tech billionaire manipulating global infrastructure.
- **The Siloviki:** Autocrat utilizing PMC “Krieger-Vanguard” for global assassinations.
- **“The Fixer”:** A Dubai-based cartel boss optimizing drug routes with AI.
- **The Contractor:** Tel Aviv spyware merchant entirely detached from the blood on his hands.

7.2 The Global Dungeons (Locations)

- **The Geneva Freeports:** Tax-free vaults holding stolen art and illegal servers.
 - **Xinjiang/Mega-City Grids:** Where avoiding a camera lens is a physical impossibility.
 - **Eastern European Black Sites:** Unmarked prisons where the legal concept of human rights does not exist.
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CHAPTER 8: Game Master's Guide: Orchestrating Terror

- **Emphasize the Scale:** The players are ants. Let them feel the crushing weight of a global supply chain turning against them.
 - **Use the Real World:** Pull headlines. If a real company gets hacked in 2026, put it in the game.
 - **Make it Personal:** The cartels don't attack the player's strongpoint; they attack the player's civilian brother.
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CHAPTER 9: Automated Scenario Generation (ZSCM)

9.1 The Zero Sum Consistency Matrix

The ZSCM is a mathematical framework to ensure scenarios maintain the brutal asymmetry of the genre. * *E*: Antagonist Power (1-10) * *R*: Player Starting Resources (1-10) * *I*: Initial Heat Level (1-10) * *D*: Degrees of Separation (1-5)

9.2 The Mathematical Theorems

1. **The Asymmetry Theorem:** $E = \min(10, \max(5, R + \lfloor I/2 \rfloor))$. The antagonist must be mathematically superior while respecting the 1-10 bounded scale.
2. **The Shadow Theorem:** $D \geq 3$. The true boss uses proxies. Direct conflict breaks the paranoia.
3. **The Footprint Theorem:** Digital MacGuffins require physical infiltration of locations possessing High Security Tiers.

9.3 The Automated Script

Use the included `scenario_generator.py` to automatically roll and mathematically verify scenarios against these theorems.

Core Gameplay Loop

At the heart of *Zero Sum* is the D10 Dice Pool system, representing a character's technical proficiency, tactical training, and psychological endurance. To perform an action, players roll a number of D10s equal to their relevant attribute and skill, counting any die that lands on a 6 or higher as a Success. Complex tasks require multiple Successes, and the environment is entirely hostile: combat is lethal, resources are strictly monetized,

and every action carries systemic risk. There are no supernatural threats—only the terrifying reality of debt, surveillance, and corporate violence.

The psychological toll of this existence is tracked through **Cognitive Load**, **Desensitization**, and **Psychological Burn**. As players witness atrocities or compromise their morals for survival, their Cognitive Load increases. If unmanaged, this escalating Load hardens into Desensitization, permanently stripping away their humanity and empathy. Reaching critical mass results in Psychological Burn, where the character suffers a complete, debilitating breakdown in the face of the crushing bureaucratic nightmare they are trapped within.

Metadata Exhaust

Metadata Exhaust complements Cognitive Load perfectly. While Cognitive Load represents *internal* psychological deterioration, Metadata Exhaust represents *external* systemic heat. Every time a player uses a digital tool, engages in combat, or utilizes a Tie, they generate Metadata Exhaust. When a player's Exhaust exceeds their Technical Attribute, the GM automatically gains a "Parallel Construction" token—allowing the GM to suddenly freeze bank accounts, revoke digital access, or deploy a corporate hit squad.

The Grey-Market Wash (Scrubbing Exhaust): To scrub Metadata Exhaust, players must physically interact with the game's Analogue Mechanics during Downtime. A player can hand physical **Analogue Market tokens** (representing untraceable cash or physical favors) to the GM to "pay off" a data scrubber at a 1-to-1 ratio (1 token = 1 Exhaust removed).

If the player is out of physical tokens, they can still scrub their Exhaust, but they must explicitly write a new, permanent line item in their physical **Debt Ledger** (e.g., "Owe Apex-Sovereign one favor - \$50,000 equivalent"). The physical act of writing the debt permanently binds the character to the corporations they are fighting. For every new debt written, they reduce their Metadata Exhaust by 1.